

Plato and Aristotle — MCQ Solutions

Philosophy Optional • Paper I • Western Philosophy

Open only after attempting the corresponding question. Each solution preserves the complete canonical answer, option analysis and examiner trap.

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MCQ 1. What the theory of Forms is posited to solve

Consider the following statements about Plato's motivation for positing Forms (*eidē*).

1. Many sensible things are called by the same predicate, so a single intelligible character must be common to them.
2. Strict knowledge (*epistēmē*) requires an object that does not change, which sensible particulars cannot supply.
3. The theory is introduced principally to explain the efficient production of motion in the sensible world.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1 and 3 only
- B. 1 and 2 only
- C. 2 and 3 only
- D. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: B.

Option explanations: - **A:** Incorrect: it pairs the sound one-over-many premise with the one function Forms notoriously fail to discharge, since Aristotle's standing objection at *Metaphysics* I.9 is precisely that separated Forms cannot originate motion. - **B:** Correct: the one-over-many argument (*hen epi pollōn*) and the argument from knowledge are the two load-bearing motivations, running from *Republic* V–VII and reported again at *Parmenides* 132a. - **C:** Incorrect: statement 2 is sound but statement 3 imports an efficient-causal role that the middle dialogues never assign to Forms and that the *Timaeus* hands instead to the Demiurge. - **D:** Incorrect: accepting all three treats an objection against the theory as though it were one of the theory's own purposes.

Examiner trap 1: Writing that Forms were introduced to explain change inverts the doctrine. Forms are introduced to explain stability and intelligibility *despite* change; explaining change is Aristotle's project, not Plato's.

MCQ 2. The exact sense of the "separation" of the Forms

When Plato is said to hold that Forms are separate from sensible particulars, the claim is best understood as meaning that

- A. Forms occupy a second physical location, lying spatially remote from the world our senses reach
- B. Forms are shared concepts assembled in the minds of those who use a common predicate correctly
- C. Forms exist independently of their sensible instances and are non-spatial and non-temporal
- D. Forms are the microscopic constituents out of which sensible particulars are assembled

Answer: C.

Option explanations: - **A:** Incorrect: "intelligible realm" is a structural expression, not a geography; a Form has no magnitude, shape or position, so it cannot be somewhere at all. - **B:** Incorrect: this is conceptualism, which Plato rejects — the Form of Beauty would then depend on minds, whereas Plato needs it to be the standard against which minds are corrected. - **C:** Correct: separation is ontological independence plus non-spatiality and non-temporality, which is exactly what the 2025 "timeless and spaceless" demand tests. - **D:** Incorrect: making Forms physical parts revives the participation dilemma of *Parmenides* 131a–c, where a divided Form of Smallness would absurdly make its participants large.

Examiner trap 2: The word "realm" is safe only if you immediately deny that it names a place. Candidates who describe a second world with Forms sitting in it hand the examiner Aristotle's duplication objection ready-made.

MCQ 3. Matching each argument for the Forms to its structure

Match each argument with its distinctive move.

1. One-over-many — 2. Argument from knowledge — 3. Argument from opposites — 4. Recollection (*anamnēsis*)

I. Sensible things are both F and not-F in different relations, whereas the F itself never is. II. We judge sensibles as falling short of a perfection we never met in sense, so the soul must have known it before. III. A common predicate applied to many requires one thing they all share. IV. Knowledge needs a stable object, and sensibles are in flux.

Which of the following is the correct matching?

A. 1–III, 2–IV, 3–I, 4–II

B. 1–IV, 2–III, 3–II, 4–I

C. 1–III, 2–I, 3–IV, 4–II

D. 1–II, 2–IV, 3–I, 4–III

Answer: A.

Option explanations: - **A:** Correct: one-over-many supplies the unity premise, the knowledge argument supplies the stability premise, the opposites argument at *Phaedo* 74a–75d supplies the non-relativity premise, and recollection at *Phaedo* 72e–77a and *Meno* 80d–86c supplies the access premise. - **B:** Incorrect: it swaps the unity and stability premises and misassigns recollection to the relativity of sensibles. - **C:** Incorrect: it makes the argument from knowledge turn on compresence of opposites, which is a distinct argument with a distinct textual home. - **D:** Incorrect: it treats one-over-many as an argument about the pre-natal soul and reduces recollection to a claim about shared predicates.

Examiner trap 3: Recollection is one supporting route to the Forms, not Plato's whole epistemology. Answers that reduce Platonic knowledge to remembering lose the *Republic's* dialectical ascent entirely.

MCQ 4. "Ideas are timeless and spaceless"

The property that most directly explains why Forms can be objects of knowledge rather than of opinion is that they

- A. are more numerous and far more finely differentiated than the sensible things that imitate them
- B. admit no generation or alteration and occupy no position, being self-identically what they are
- C. are perceived by an inner sense which operates on much the same principles as ordinary sight
- D. change far more slowly than sensible particulars and therefore approximate stability more closely

Answer: B.

Option explanations: - **A:** Incorrect: number and differentiation are irrelevant to knowability; a large collection of changing items would still yield only opinion. - **B:** Correct: timelessness and spacelessness make a Form incapable of being otherwise, and only what cannot be otherwise can be known in Plato's strict sense. - **C:** Incorrect: Forms are grasped by reason (*nous*), not by any sense; an "inner sense" reading collapses the very distinction the 2025 question tests. - **D:** Incorrect: degrees of slowness keep Forms inside time, whereas the claim is that they are outside it and therefore admit no comparative rate of change at all.

Examiner trap 4: "Eternal" is not the answer by itself. The examiner wants the inference — non-temporal and non-spatial, therefore incapable of being otherwise, therefore knowable — not a restatement of the adjective.

MCQ 5. What counts as substance for Plato

On Plato's view, true substance (*ousia*) is

- A. the concrete individual before us, since it alone is the ultimate subject of every predication
- B. the underlying matter, which persists unchanged through every change the individual undergoes
- C. the compound formed from an intelligible structure and a portion of the Receptacle
- D. the universal Form, with particulars possessing being only derivatively through participation

Answer: D.

Option explanations: - **A:** Incorrect: this is Aristotle's *Categories* answer, and stating it as Plato's erases the inversion on which every comparison question turns. - **B:** Incorrect: Plato has no doctrine of matter as substance; the nearest item, the Receptacle (*chōra*) of the *Timaeus*, is a difficult "third kind" and is expressly not straightforward Aristotelian matter. - **C:** Incorrect: it fuses a *Timaeus* cosmological notion with a hylomorphic analysis that belongs to Aristotle, producing a doctrine neither philosopher holds. - **D:** Correct: for Plato the universal is the truly real (*ontōs on*) and the particular is a derivative copy, which is the exact reverse of Aristotle's primary substance.

Examiner trap 5: Do not soften this into "both thought universals and particulars are real". The marks lie in naming the inversion sharply and then showing what it costs each thinker.

MCQ 6. The Divided Line

In the Divided Line of *Republic* VI 509d–511e, the ascending order of states of mind and their objects is

- A. *pistis* — images; *eikasia* — visible things; *noēsis* — mathematical objects; *dianoia* — Forms
- B. *eikasia* — visible things; *pistis* — images; *dianoia* — Forms; *noēsis* — mathematical objects
- C. *dianoia* — images; *noēsis* — visible things; *eikasia* — mathematical objects; *pistis* — Forms
- D. *eikasia* — images; *pistis* — visible things; *dianoia* — mathematical objects; *noēsis* — Forms

Answer: D.

Option explanations: - **A:** Incorrect: it inverts the two lower states and inverts the two higher ones, destroying the correspondence between degree of clarity and degree of being. - **B:** Incorrect: shadows and reflections belong to conjecture (*eikasia*), not to belief (*pistis*), and dialectic terminates in Forms rather than in mathematical objects. - **C:** Incorrect: it assigns the two intellectual states to the visible section, which contradicts the primary cut of the line. - **D:** Correct: conjecture takes images, belief takes visible originals, thought takes mathematical objects and intellection takes the Forms culminating in the Good.

Examiner trap 6: The line is one scale read twice — clarity in the knower matched to being in the known. Reproducing the four names without that correspondence answers only half the question.

MCQ 7. What separates *dianoia* from *noēsi*

The decisive difference between thought (*dianoia*) and intellection (*noēsis*) in the Divided Line lies in

- A. the relative difficulty of the subject matter, geometry being distinctly easier than dialectic
- B. the direction of argument and the use of images, mathematics reasoning downward from hypotheses
- C. the number of premises each one employs, dialectic requiring more steps than geometrical demonstration
- D. the fact that only intellection is exercised by philosophers, since mathematics belongs to artisans

Answer: B.

Option explanations: - **A:** Incorrect: difficulty is a psychological accident; Plato's criterion is methodological, which is why the distinction survives even for an easy piece of dialectic. - **B:** Correct: mathematics takes the odd and the even and the figures "as known" and gives no account of them, while dialectic treats hypotheses as steps up to an unhypothetical principle (*archē anhypothetos*) and descends through Forms alone. - **C:** Incorrect: length of proof is not a criterion anywhere in the passage and would make the classification vary with the theorem chosen. - **D:** Incorrect: the distinction concerns methods, not professions; the mathematician's method remains *dianoia* however philosophical the practitioner.

Examiner trap 7: This is the single most examinable point in the Line. An answer that names the four segments but cannot say *why* mathematics falls short has given a description where an analysis was demanded.

MCQ 8. What the Cave adds to the Line

Consider the following statements about the Allegory of the Cave, *Republic* VII 514a–517a.

1. The ascent is described as painful and compelled, and education is presented as turning an organ of vision the soul already possesses.
2. The philosopher must descend again into the cave, will see badly in the dark and may be met with ridicule or violence.
3. The allegory replaces the epistemological scheme of the Line with an independent political doctrine.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1 only
- B. 2 and 3 only
- C. 1 and 2 only
- D. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: C.

Option explanations: - **A:** Incorrect: it drops the return (*katabasis*), which is the feature that converts the allegory into an argument about who should rule. - **B:** Incorrect: statement 3 is false, so any combination containing it fails; Plato himself insists at 517a–b that the image "must be applied as a whole" to what preceded. - **C:** Correct: compulsion and conversion (*periagōgē*), together with the descent and its transparent allusion to Socrates, are exactly what the Line does not contain. - **D:** Incorrect: the Cave extends the Line into education and politics; it does not displace the epistemology it narrates.

Examiner trap 8: Retelling the story is the classic way to lose a ten-mark answer. Map the four stages onto the four segments, then add compulsion and the return, and the narrative becomes an argument.

MCQ 9. The Sun analogy

In the Sun analogy of *Republic* VI 507a–509c, the Form of the Good stands to the intelligible order as the sun stands to the visible order because the Good

- A. illuminates the Forms for the mind without contributing anything at all to what they are
- B. confers on the Forms both their knowability and their being, and lies itself beyond being
- C. is the efficient craftsman who fashions the Forms out of some pre-existing material stuff
- D. is simply the highest member of the class of Forms, differing from all the rest only in rank

Answer: B.

Option explanations: - **A:** Incorrect: the analogy is deliberately double — as the sun gives visibility *and* generation, the Good gives knowability *and* being. - **B:** Correct: this reproduces both limbs of the analogy and Plato's most audacious phrase, that the Good is "beyond being" (*epekeina tēs ousias*) at 509b. - **C:** Incorrect: the craftsman is the Demiurge of the *Timaeus*, a different dialogue with a different explanatory role, and he does not create the Forms. - **D:** Incorrect: mere seniority would not explain why the other Forms depend on it for being, nor would it license the "beyond being" formula.

Examiner trap 9: Equating the Form of the Good with the Demiurge, or with a personal creator, is a standing error. Keep the *Republic's* principle and the *Timaeus's* craftsman apart and say why.

MCQ 10. The participation dilemma

The dilemma about participation raised at *Parmenides* 131a–c presses the question whether

- A. the whole Form or only a part of it is present in each participant, neither answer being coherent
- B. Forms exist at all, given that nobody has ever perceived a single one of them by sight or touch
- C. participation is really a relation between two Forms rather than between a Form and a particular
- D. the Form of the Good participates in the lesser Forms in the way that particulars participate in Forms

Answer: A.

Option explanations: - **A:** Correct: both horns are stated in the text, and together they show that "sharing in" has not yet been given a coherent analysis. - **B:** Incorrect: imperceptibility is a premise Plato accepts happily, not an objection; the dilemma is internal to the theory rather than empiricist. - **C:** Incorrect: relations among the highest kinds belong to the *Sophist's* later refinement, not to the participation dilemma. - **D:** Incorrect: the Good's relation to the other Forms is a question about grounding, and it is not the whole-or-part problem raised here.

Examiner trap 10: Plato states this objection against himself. Presenting the *Parmenides* difficulties as Aristotle's discoveries misreports the source and wastes the strongest evidence of Plato's philosophical honesty.

MCQ 11. The presuppositions of the Third Man

The regress known as the Third Man requires which pair of assumptions?

- A. That Forms are causally inert, and that sensible particulars are altogether unreal things
- B. That knowledge is recollection, and that the soul pre-exists the body it later occupies
- C. That the Form of F is itself F, and that the explaining Form differs from what it explains
- D. That every predicate has its own Form, and that the sensible world is in a ceaseless flux

Answer: C.

Option explanations: - **A:** Incorrect: causal inertness is a separate Aristotelian objection, and the regress does not need particulars to be unreal — only to resemble the Form. - **B:** Incorrect: recollection is an argument for Forms, not a premise of the regress against them. - **C:** Correct: self-predication plus non-identity generate the further Form at each stage, which is why denying self-predication is the standard Platonic escape route. - **D:** Incorrect: the scope of Forms and the flux of sensibles are background theses; neither of them, alone or together, yields a regress.

Examiner trap 11: Name the two premises. An answer that merely says "an infinite regress of Forms follows" cannot show where the argument may be blocked, and blocking it is what a critical evaluation requires.

MCQ 12. Plato's wider causal resources

Which statement most accurately describes Plato's explanatory apparatus once the *Timaeus* is taken into account?

- A. Forms give formal explanation, the Good grounds being and intelligibility, and the Demiurge orders becoming after the Forms
- B. The Form of the Good and the Demiurge are two names for one creator who produces the Forms and the sensible world alike
- C. The Receptacle (*chōra*) is Plato's term for matter and functions exactly as Aristotle's *hylē* does in hylomorphic analysis
- D. Plato offers only one kind of cause, so Aristotle's charge that he cannot explain motion applies without any qualification

Answer: A.

Option explanations: - **A:** Correct: it keeps three explanatory roles distinct and states the Demiurge's limits, which is the qualification the examiner rewards. - **B:** Incorrect: identifying the Good with the Demiurge collapses a *Republic* principle into a *Timaeus* craftsman and is interpretively contested at best. - **C:** Incorrect: the Receptacle is a difficult third kind in which becoming appears, and it is not straightforwardly identical with Aristotelian matter. - **D:** Incorrect: Plato has more than one explanatory resource; Aristotle's sharper charge is that *separated Forms themselves* do not explain motion or internal organisation.

Examiner trap 12: State Aristotle's objection in its accurate form. "Plato has no causes" is false and easily rebutted; "separated Forms cannot cause" is true and cannot be rebutted.

MCQ 13. Aristotle's critique of separated Forms

Which of the following states the "duplication" objection of *Metaphysics* I.9 correctly?

- A. Forms cannot be defined at all, because definition requires a genus and a differentia that Forms lack
- B. Forms are wholly unknowable, because knowledge proceeds only from the sense-perception of particulars

- C. Separated Forms double the entities requiring explanation, leaving two sets where there was one
- D. Forms are impossible, because nothing whatever can exist that is not located in space and in time

Answer: C.

Option explanations: - **A:** Incorrect: this is a difficulty about definability that Aristotle raises elsewhere, and it is not the parsimony charge the question names. - **B:** Incorrect: Aristotle holds that knowledge begins from sense and reaches universals, which is a positive epistemology rather than the duplication objection. - **C:** Correct: Stace summarises the charge with Aristotle's own barb that the Ideas are "nothing but eternalized things of nature", so the explanatory debt is merely transferred. - **D:** Incorrect: Aristotle nowhere argues that only spatio-temporal things exist — his own Unmoved Mover is immaterial.

Examiner trap 13: Keep Aristotle's five objections distinct: the Third Man regress, duplication, participation as metaphor, causal impotence and the absence of any account of generation. A merged blur earns one mark where five separated arguments earn several.

MCQ 14. Aristotle's repair of the theory of Forms

Aristotle's response to Plato is best described as

- A. rejecting form and universality altogether in favour of a strict materialism of atoms and void
- B. retaining Plato's separated Forms while adding efficient causation so as to make them effective
- C. accepting the Forms for mathematical objects while denying them for natural substances
- D. retaining intelligible form but making it immanent in the composite rather than separate

Answer: D.

Option explanations: - **A:** Incorrect: Aristotle keeps form as the central explanatory principle, and atomism is the rival position he argues against. - **B:** Incorrect: separation is precisely what he removes; adding an efficient cause to a separated Form would leave the regress and duplication charges untouched. - **C:** Incorrect: he denies separate existence to mathematical objects too, and reports Plato's "intermediates" as a doctrine he does not share. - **D:** Correct: the same word *eidos* is retained with a changed ontological status, which is the hinge of the 2024 comparison question.

Examiner trap 14: "Aristotle rejected the Forms" is a half-truth that reads as an error. He rejects their *separate existence* and their priority over individuals, and that precision is worth marks.

MCQ 15. Substance in the *Categories*

In the *Categories* (2a11 ff.), primary and secondary substance are related as follows.

- A. Primary substance is the species and secondary substance is the individual, since the species is more knowable
- B. Primary substance is the essence and secondary substance is the matter, since the essence explains the matter

- C. Primary substance is the concrete individual, and species and genus are secondary substances said of it
- D. Primary substance is the genus and secondary substance is the accident, since accidents inhere in genera

Answer: C.

Option explanations: - **A:** Incorrect: it reverses Aristotle's order and thereby reinstates the Platonic priority of the universal that the *Categories* is designed to overturn. - **B:** Incorrect: essence and matter are the vocabulary of the *Metaphysics*, not the predication-based scheme of the *Categories*. - **C:** Correct: "this man" and "this horse" (*tode ti*) are the ultimate subjects of predication, and everything else is said of them or is in them. - **D:** Incorrect: accidents are not substances at all in this scheme, and the genus is the more remote of the two secondary substances.

Examiner trap 15: The *Categories* answers "which things are substances?" by a logical criterion of subjecthood. Importing the *Metaphysics* answer here, or vice versa, is the commonest structural error in substance questions.

MCQ 16. The four candidates for substance in *Metaphysics* Z.3

Aristotle reviews substratum, essence, universal and genus as candidates for substance. His adjudication is that

- A. essence is accepted, the universal and the genus are rejected, and bare matter is neither a "this" nor separable
- B. the substratum taken as matter is accepted, because stripping away predicates leaves the one thing that truly underlies
- C. the genus is accepted, because it is the widest term under which the thing in question may be classified
- D. the universal is accepted, since Aristotle agrees with Plato that only what is common to many can explain

Answer: A.

Option explanations: - **A:** Correct: Z.3 rejects bare matter as a candidate, Z.4–6 and Z.17 install essence (*to ti ēn einai*), and Z.13 rules out the universal while the genus falls as predicated of many. - **B:** Incorrect: it accepts exactly the candidate Z.3 eliminates, since what remains after every predicate is removed is neither determinate nor separable. - **C:** Incorrect: a genus is predicated of many and therefore fails the same test that disqualifies the universal. - **D:** Incorrect: Aristotle's agreement with Plato ends precisely here; Z.13 states that no universal is a substance.

Examiner trap 16: Reproduce the list with the verdicts attached. A candidate who names the four candidates without saying which are rejected and why has described a procedure instead of using it.

MCQ 17. The *Categories*/*Metaphysics* question

The safest way to handle the apparent conflict between the *Categories* and *Metaphysics* Z is to argue that

- A. the *Metaphysics* silently withdraws the *Categories*, so only the later of the two doctrines should be reported
- B. the two works are simply inconsistent and Aristotle himself never noticed the problem at all
- C. the two works answer different questions — which things are substances, and what the substance *of* a thing is
- D. "substance" is used equivocally in the two works, with no philosophical connection at all between the senses

Answer: C.

Option explanations: - **A:** Incorrect: the developmental reading is available but rests on a disputed chronology, so it cannot be offered as the safe primary line. - **B:** Incorrect: Z.17 shows Aristotle reformulating the question deliberately, which is evidence of design rather than oversight. - **C:** Correct: the individual remains what exists in the primary way, while its form accounts for its being the individual it is — and Aristotle insists that being is said in many ways. - **D:** Incorrect: bare equivocation severs the link, whereas Z.17's question "why is this matter a house?" shows the second sense explaining the first.

Examiner trap 17: Name at least two readings. Mentioning only the different-questions solution loses the credit available for the developmental, individual-form and species-form alternatives, each of which should be flagged as contested.

MCQ 18. The ten categories

The ten categories of the *Categories* are best described as

- A. fundamental modes of predication and of being, only substance being a subject primarily
- B. ten physical components which jointly compose every material object that we encounter in nature
- C. ten successive stages through which every natural substance passes as it develops to maturity
- D. ten distinct kinds of cause, of which the final cause is much the most important of all

Answer: A.

Option explanations: - **A:** Correct: substance, quantity, quality, relation, place, time, position, state, action and being affected classify ways of being said, and the nine non-substantial categories are in or said of substances. - **B:** Incorrect: treating them as parts inside a thing is a category mistake in the literal sense; "yesterday" and "taller than Simmias" are not ingredients. - **C:** Incorrect: developmental stages belong to the analysis of change through potentiality and actuality, not to the classification of predicates. - **D:** Incorrect: the causes are four and belong to *Physics* II.3 and *Metaphysics* V, a different doctrine entirely.

Examiner trap 18: Substance *is*; accidents *belong to* substance. Fix that asymmetry first, and the difference between alteration and generation follows without further argument.

MCQ 19. Matter and form in hylomorphic analysis

Which statement about matter (*hylē*) and form (*morphē*) is correct?

- A. Matter and form are two independently existing objects that a craftsman joins mechanically together
- B. Matter is always the same featureless stuff, so bronze and wood differ only in the forms imposed on them
- C. Form is a separately existing paradigm that the matter of each substance imitates at a distance
- D. Matter is relative, since bronze is matter for the statue yet is itself formed from copper and tin

Answer: D.

Option explanations: - **A:** Incorrect: they are principles of analysis, not parts in a box; if they were separable objects the unity of the composite would be lost. - **B:** Incorrect: it confuses proximate matter, which is always already determinate, with the limiting notion of prime matter. - **C:** Incorrect: that is the Platonic paradigm relation, which Aristotle's immanent form is designed to replace. - **D:** Correct: relativity of matter and correlativity of the pair are the two features that let one scheme cover artefacts, organisms, change and definition.

Examiner trap 19: The 2025 statement "everything in the empirical world is a compound of Matter and Form" must be evaluated, not merely endorsed. It holds of sensible substances; accidents taken apart, mathematical abstractions and the immaterial Unmoved Mover are not further compounds in the same sense.

MCQ 20. Prime matter

The doctrine of prime matter (*prōtē hylē*) is best presented in an answer as

- A. a limiting posit of matter considered without determinate form and never existing independently
- B. an observable featureless stuff that chemists have since identified with the elementary particles
- C. a synonym for the Receptacle of Plato's *Timaeus*, which Aristotle adopted without any change
- D. the substantial form that is shared by all material things whatever their species may be

Answer: A.

Option explanations: - **A:** Correct: it is required to explain radical generation but is never actual on its own, and how far Aristotle commits to a single featureless prime matter is contested. - **B:** Incorrect: presenting a limit concept as an observed stuff is exactly the error that invites the charge of unintelligibility. - **C:** Incorrect: the Receptacle is Plato's difficult third kind and is not straightforwardly Aristotelian matter. - **D:** Incorrect: it inverts the definition, since prime matter is characterised by the absence of determinate form rather than by possessing a universal one.

Examiner trap 20: Concede the objection and then answer it. "Prime matter is unintelligible" is a real criticism; the reply is that it is a limit concept demanded by substantial generation, not a candidate for observation.

MCQ 21. The four causes

Which statement about the four causes (*aitiai*) is correct?

- A. They are four successive events, so the material cause acts first and the final cause acts last
- B. They are four competing hypotheses, of which the investigator must select the single true one
- C. They are four agents that act upon a thing from outside and may be observed quite separately
- D. They are four answers to "why?" about one thing, and in nature three of them typically coincide

Answer: D.

Option explanations: - **A:** Incorrect: the four can be simultaneous, and Stace notes that in every case of production all four operate together rather than in sequence. - **B:** Incorrect: they are complementary rather than rival; a complete explanation gives all four. - **C:** Incorrect: the material and formal causes are internal principles, and only the efficient cause is typically an external agent. - **D:** Correct: the form of the oak is what the acorn is for and what directs its development, which is why Aristotelian teleology is internal rather than designed.

Examiner trap 21: Use one worked example — the statue or the house — through all four causes. Four definitions attached to four different examples reads as a glossary, not as an explanation.

MCQ 22. Change, privation and the two kinds of change

Consider the following statements about Aristotle's analysis of change.

1. Coming-to-be is analysed through an underlying subject, an acquired form and the prior privation (*sterēsis*) of that form.
2. In accidental change the substantial form persists while a quantity, quality, place or other accident alters.
3. In substantial generation the prior substantial form persists as the identity of the new substance.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1 and 2 only
- B. 2 and 3 only
- C. 1 and 3 only
- D. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: A.

Option explanations: - **A:** Correct: the unmusical man becoming musical illustrates subject, form and privation, and accidental change is precisely the case in which the substance survives. - **B:** Incorrect: statement 3 is false, because in substantial generation an underlying material potential acquires a *new* substantial form. - **C:** Incorrect: it retains the same false claim about substantial change while dropping the correct account of accidental change. - **D:** Incorrect: accepting 3 would make generation indistinguishable from alteration and would leave destruction unexplained.

Examiner trap 22: Reserve "the form persists" for accidental change. Saying it of substantial generation contradicts the doctrine and undermines any answer on developmental change in substance.

MCQ 23. Potentiality and actuality

Aristotle's definition of change at *Physics* III.1 (201a10) is best rendered as

- A. the actuality of the potential as potential, a passage from potential to actual being
- B. the replacement of one actual thing by another actual thing that is numerically different
- C. the movement of matter through space under the action of some external moving agency
- D. the appearance of a wholly new being out of absolute non-being at each successive moment

Answer: A.

Option explanations: - **A:** Correct: the qualification "as potential" is what makes the formula describe the process rather than its completed result. - **B:** Incorrect: replacement without an underlying potential reintroduces the Parmenidean problem that the doctrine is designed to solve. - **C:** Incorrect: locomotion is only one species of change; Aristotle's *kinēsis* also covers alteration, growth and generation. - **D:** Incorrect: creation from absolute non-being is exactly what Aristotle denies, since nothing comes from nothing.

Examiner trap 23: Do not drop the phrase "as potential". Without it the definition collapses into the description of a finished actuality and answers nothing about becoming.

MCQ 24. The priority of actuality

Aristotle argues that actuality (*energeia*) is prior to potentiality (*dynamis*) in which respects?

- A. In spatial position, in numerical count and in bare perceptibility to the senses
- B. In causal power, in metaphysical dignity and in popularity among his later successors
- C. In explanatory efficiency, in theoretical economy and in the overall simplicity of statement
- D. In definition, in time at the species level, and in substance as the end of the process

Answer: D.

Option explanations: - **A:** Incorrect: none of these is a mode of priority Aristotle recognises, and Forms and actualities are not spatially ordered at all. - **B:** Incorrect: dignity and reception are rhetorical rather than metaphysical grounds and prove nothing about the relation of the two notions. - **C:** Incorrect:

methodological virtues are not the argument; the argument concerns definition, generation and end. - **D:** Correct: to define "potentially F" you must already grasp actual F; only an actual oak produces acorns; and the end is what the process is for.

Examiner trap 24: Priority is explanatory, definitional and teleological — not temporal in every sense. An individual potential state can precede its own actualisation in time, and conceding that openly strengthens the answer.

MCQ 25. Remedial drill — what Plato says about the physical world

A candidate writes that Plato "denies the reality of the physical world". The correct correction is that Plato

- A. holds the sensible world to be a systematic illusion projected by ignorance, much as Advaita treats *māyā*
- B. grants sensible particulars a real but derivative being as copies of Forms, hence objects of opinion
- C. treats the physical world as fully real and equal in status to the Forms, differing only in accessibility
- D. leaves the ontological status of the physical world entirely undetermined throughout the dialogues

Answer: B.

Option explanations: - **A:** Incorrect: illusionism is precisely the position Plato does not hold; a copy is a defective instance of what it copies, not a non-entity. - **B:** Correct: derivative reality is the accurate formula, and it explains why sensibles yield belief (*pistis*) rather than nothing at all. - **C:** Incorrect: equal status would destroy the argument that different faculties must have different objects, argued at *Republic* V 476e–480a. - **D:** Incorrect: the two-level scheme assigns the sensible world a definite subordinate status, so indeterminacy is not the reading.

Examiner trap 25: Comparisons with Advaita's *māyā* are legitimate only when the difference is stated. Plato degrades the sensible world's rank; he does not deny that it is there.

MCQ 26. Remedial drill — what Aristotle denies about universals

Which correction of the claim that "Aristotle denies universals" is accurate?

- A. He denies universals in logic but retains them in physics, where species-terms are indispensable
- B. He accepts universals as separately existing entities but denies that they can ever be known
- C. He accepts universals only as names, holding that nothing in reality corresponds to a general term
- D. He retains species and genus as secondary substances, denying only their separate existence

Answer: D.

Option explanations: - **A:** Incorrect: the same account of universals runs through both, since predication in the *Categories* is not restricted by subject matter. - **B:** Incorrect: separate existence is what he rejects, and universals are for him precisely what science knows. - **C:** Incorrect: nominalism is a later medieval position; Aristotle grounds the universal in the immanent form of the individual. - **D:** Correct: "man" and "animal" remain secondary substances, less real than *this* man, which is the exact and defensible formulation.

Examiner trap 26: Precision here converts a wrong answer into a strong one. Write "he rejects *separated* Forms", never "he rejects forms", and the entire comparison keeps its balance.

MCQ 27. Remedial drill — what potentiality is not

The claim that "potentiality is indefinable", tested in 2021, is best explained by saying that potentiality

- A. is a statistical likelihood that a given outcome will occur, measurable in principle by frequency
- B. cannot be defined independently of actuality, since "potentially a table" presupposes an actual table
- C. is undefinable because Aristotle nowhere discusses it, leaving only later commentators to supply an account
- D. is a hidden quality inside matter that can be detected once the matter is sufficiently divided

Answer: B.

Option explanations: - **A:** Incorrect: *dynamis* is an ontological capacity of a determinate material, not a probability; wood is potentially a table whatever the frequency of carpentry. - **B:** Correct: this is why actuality is conceptually prior even where the potential state precedes in the individual's own time. - **C:** Incorrect: *Metaphysics* IX (Θ) is devoted to the pair, so silence is not the ground of indefinability. - **D:** Incorrect: division reveals more matter, never a capacity; the capacity is intelligible only through the actuality it is a capacity for.

Examiner trap 27: The wooden-table example must run through all three stages — block of wood, the carpenter's working, the finished table — and must be labelled *dynamis*, *kinēsis* and *energeia/entelecheia*. A bare example without the vocabulary is half an answer.

MCQ 28. Remedial drill — how the Unmoved Mover moves

The Unmoved Mover of *Metaphysics* XII (Λ).7 moves the cosmos

- A. by efficient causation, imparting motion to the outermost sphere by direct physical contact with it
- B. by creating the world out of nothing at a first moment of time, before which nothing existed
- C. as a final cause, being the object of desire and thought — it "moves as the beloved moves the lover"
- D. by continuously sustaining matter in existence, acting as a conserving cause at every instant

Answer: C.

Option explanations: - **A:** Incorrect: pushing would make the mover itself moved and would reintroduce the potentiality that pure actuality excludes. - **B:** Incorrect: creation from nothing at a first moment is a later theological doctrine; Aristotle's cosmos and its motion are eternal. - **C:** Correct: attraction rather than propulsion is the whole point, and it is why the mover can be immaterial, changeless and thought thinking itself (*noēsis noēseōs*). - **D:** Incorrect: conservation belongs to the scholastic development of the doctrine, not to Aristotle's own argument.

Examiner trap 28: Do not assimilate the Unmoved Mover to a personal creator. It completes the actuality–potentiality system as the ultimate explanatory terminus, and saying so keeps the answer inside the printed clause.

MCQ 29. Remedial drill — the four causes as explanation, not narrative

A script states: "First the material cause supplies wood, then the efficient cause acts, then the formal cause appears, and finally the final cause is reached." The error is that

- A. the order given is right but the labels have been interchanged between the formal and final causes
- B. the four are aspects of one explanation and may be simultaneous rather than successive events
- C. there are five causes on Aristotle's mature view, and the list omits the instrumental cause
- D. only the efficient cause is a genuine cause, the other three being metaphors for it

Answer: B.

Option explanations: - **A:** Incorrect: relabelling leaves the deeper mistake untouched, which is the conversion of an explanatory scheme into a chronology. - **B:** Correct: Aristotelian causation includes what we would call reasons as well as causes, and all four operate together in any case of production. - **C:** Incorrect: the causes are four, and the instrumental factor is an aspect of efficient causation rather than a fifth kind. - **D:** Incorrect: reducing the four to the efficient cause is the modern narrowing that Aristotle's scheme is designed to resist.

Examiner trap 29: The word "cause" is wider in Aristotle than in modern usage. Say so in one clause, and the four-cause doctrine stops looking like bad physics and starts looking like a theory of explanation.

MCQ 30. Remedial drill — formal cause and Platonic Form

The relation between Aristotle's formal cause and Plato's Form is that

- A. they are the same entity described in two vocabularies, so the dispute between the two philosophers is merely verbal
- B. both are called *eidos*, but Aristotle's is immanent in *this* composite and Plato's is separate
- C. the formal cause is a mental concept, whereas the Platonic Form is an object outside the mind
- D. Aristotle abandoned the word *eidos* precisely in order to mark his break with his teacher

Answer: B.

Option explanations: - **A:** Incorrect: separation versus immanence changes what the entity can do, so the dispute is substantive rather than terminological. - **B:** Correct: the shared word with a changed ontological status is exactly what makes this the favourite trap in comparison questions. - **C:** Incorrect: making the formal cause mental is conceptualism, which neither philosopher accepts. - **D:** Incorrect: he retains the word deliberately, which is why the distinction must be drawn by ontological status rather than by vocabulary.

Examiner trap 30: In the 2024 comparison, run one axis — separated paradigm versus immanent essence — and then derive the consequences for causation, generation, universals and substance. Two parallel summaries score poorly.

MCQ 31. Remedial drill — the standing of the "mathematicals"

The doctrine that Plato posited mathematical objects as intermediates (*ta metaxu*) between Forms and sensibles should be reported as

- A. a doctrine stated explicitly in the *Republic* alongside the account of the Divided Line
- B. a modern scholarly conjecture with no ancient textual or doxographical support whatever
- C. Aristotle's testimony at *Metaphysics* I.6 (987b14), not a doctrine stated in the dialogues
- D. a Neoplatonic addition of the third century which later editors inserted into the Platonic text

Answer: C.

Option explanations: - **A:** Incorrect: the Line assigns mathematical objects to thought (*dianoia*) but never states a separate order of intermediate entities. - **B:** Incorrect: the report is ancient and is Aristotle's own, so calling it a modern conjecture misstates the evidence. - **C:** Correct: the safe formula is "on Aristotle's testimony", which shows source discipline and protects the claim from challenge. - **D:** Incorrect: there is no textual-interpolation story here, and inventing one would be a fabricated evidential claim.

Examiner trap 31: Attribute reports to their reporters. The name "Third Man" likewise comes from Aristotle at *Metaphysics* 990b17 and 1039a2; the argument itself is Plato's at *Parmenides* 132a–b.

MCQ 32. Remedial drill — citation and verdict discipline

Which answer-writing practice is defensible in this topic?

- A. Quoting long passages of Jowett's translation from memory to establish the exact wording of a Platonic argument
- B. Citing "Plato, *Republic*, Chapter 7, page 214" so that the examiner can locate the passage in a particular printed edition
- C. Ending a comparison with a balanced description of both thinkers and no ruling, since UPSC penalises taking sides

D. Citing Plato by Stephanus pagination and Aristotle by Bekker numbers, and closing with a graded verdict

Answer: D.

Option explanations: - **A:** Incorrect: translations differ markedly, so a remembered wording is the least reliable evidence available; prefer the reference to the quotation. - **B:** Incorrect: chapter and page numbers vary between editions, whereas Stephanus and Bekker references are edition-invariant. - **C:** Incorrect: a directive such as "critically discuss" or "evaluate" obliges a ruling; balanced description without a verdict answers the topic instead of the question. - **D:** Correct: edition-invariant citation plus a reasoned verdict is the combination that signals textual control and analytical nerve together.

Examiner trap 32: A verdict must follow from the body and must be graded rather than absolute — for example, that Aristotle's immanent form solves Plato's causal problem while inheriting his problem about universals.

MCQ 33. The Receptacle as a third kind

Consider the following statements about the Receptacle (*chōra*) in Plato's *Timaeus*.

1. It is introduced as a difficult third kind, distinct from the intelligible Forms and the sensible becoming that appears in it.
2. It is a determinate material body manufactured by the Demiurge before the Demiurge copies the Forms.
3. Its receiving role does not by itself make it straightforwardly identical with Aristotle's matter.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1 only
- B. 2 and 3 only
- C. 1 and 3 only
- D. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: C.

Statement analysis: - **1 is correct:** the *Timaeus* distinguishes the intelligible model, the generated copy and the Receptacle in which sensible becoming appears; "third kind" marks its exceptional ontological role. - **2 is incorrect:** the Demiurge orders becoming after the Forms but does not manufacture either the Forms or the Receptacle from nothing; describing *chōra* as an ordinary determinate body also gives it precisely the stable character it lacks. - **3 is correct:** both doctrines help articulate becoming, but *chōra* is a Platonic receiving "third kind", whereas Aristotelian matter is a correlative potential principle within a hylomorphic substance.

Option explanations: - **A:** Incorrect: it recognises the threefold ontology but omits the essential warning against translating *chōra* directly into Aristotelian *hylē*. - **B:** Incorrect: statement 3 is sound, but statement 2 turns the receptacle into a created, determinate object and misstates the Demiurge's role. - **C:** Correct: it

preserves both the Receptacle's third-kind status and the non-identity of the Platonic and Aristotelian frameworks. - **D:** Incorrect: including statement 2 collapses the ordering activity of the Demiurge into creation of the ontological field in which ordering occurs.

Examiner trap 33: "Receptacle = matter" is an attractive shortcut because both receive determinations. It erases the different systems: *chōra* belongs to the *Timaeus*' model-copy-receptacle scheme, while matter belongs to Aristotle's immanent matter-form analysis.

Repair action: Redraw the three-part *Timaeus* map — Forms as models, becoming as copies, Receptacle as the receiving third kind — and add beneath it: "not straightforwardly Aristotelian matter".

Coverage-cell mapping: Plato's causal repertoire: Forms, Good, Demiurge and Receptacle — specifically the uncovered ontological status of *chōra* as the third kind.

PYQ linkage: Supports the qualified account required in **2018 Q4(b)** on Aristotle's critique of Plato: do not answer the critique by falsely claiming that Plato supplies no cosmological or causal resources.

MCQ 34. Prime matter and substantial generation

A candidate explains radical generation by saying that prime matter is "the smallest separable stuff left after every observable property is removed". Which correction is most accurate?

- A. Prime matter is a non-separable limit concept of pure potentiality required for substantial generation, not a bare body available for inspection.
- B. Prime matter is the last determinate element surviving every substantial change, and its continued identity numerically anchors the newly generated substance.
- C. Prime matter is Aristotle's revised name for the Platonic Receptacle, now treated as the common spatial container of all sensible forms.
- D. Prime matter is dispensable because genuine generation is only accidental alteration in which the underlying substance and its substantial form both remain.

Answer: A.

Option explanations: - **A:** Correct: prime matter is matter considered without determinate form, never independently actual; its function is to mark the limiting potential principle required by radical or substantial generation. - **B:** Incorrect: a determinate surviving material is relative matter, such as bronze for a statue; in substantial generation no prior determinate substantial form persists as the identity of the new substance. - **C:** Incorrect: the Revision Guide explicitly separates prime matter from the *Timaeus* Receptacle; similar receiving language does not establish doctrinal identity. - **D:** Incorrect: it reduces all change to accidental alteration and thereby makes the distinction between accidental change and substantial generation unintelligible.

Examiner trap 34: Treating prime matter as microscopic stuff makes it an observable substance, while Aristotle introduces it precisely as a limiting posit that is never bare. The opposite trap is to discard it and then leave radical generation without an underlying potential principle.

Repair action: Practise a three-line contrast: relative matter is determinate; prime matter is a non-separable limit; substantial generation acquires a new substantial form rather than preserving the old one.

Coverage-cell mapping: Hylomorphism, relative/prime matter, privation and kinds of change — specifically prime matter's non-separable limiting status in determinate substantial change.

PYQ linkage: Directly sharpens **2025 Q1(b)** on matter and form and supports **2019 Q2(b)** on developmental change by preventing the false claim that one substantial form persists through every change.

MCQ 35. What makes Aristotelian teleology internal

An acorn develops into an oak under ordinary natural conditions. Consider the following interpretations.

1. The mature form is the terminus toward which the organism's own powers are directed.
2. The explanation need not attribute conscious foresight either to the acorn or to an external designer.
3. The account differs both from imitation of a separated Platonic paradigm and from an explanation restricted to material impact and efficient sequence.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1 and 2 only
- B. 2 and 3 only
- C. 1 and 3 only
- D. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: D.

Statement analysis: - **1 is correct:** in natural development form, efficient source and final end typically converge; the oak-form organises the process and is the determinate actuality toward which the acorn develops. - **2 is correct:** internal teleology means directedness of a natural power, not a conscious plan in the organism or an externally imposed designer's intention. - **3 is correct:** Aristotle places the explanatory principle in the developing substance, unlike Platonic paradigm-copy imitation, and retains formal and final explanation against a purely material-efficient mechanism.

Option explanations: - **A:** Incorrect: statements 1 and 2 explain directedness without design, but omitting statement 3 loses the comparison that distinguishes Aristotle from both Plato and mechanism. - **B:** Incorrect: statements 2 and 3 are sound, but without statement 1 no positive account of the internal *telos* remains. - **C:** Incorrect: statements 1 and 3 are sound, but rejecting statement 2 wrongly turns natural teleology into conscious design. - **D:** Correct: all three jointly state the terminus, the absence of conscious planning and the doctrine's distance from its two principal rivals.

Examiner trap 35: "For the sake of" does not mean that an acorn deliberates or that a divine artisan pushes it toward oakhood. Conversely, stripping the account to efficient mechanism removes the final-causal feature the question is testing.

Repair action: For any organism, write one chain: internal potential → organised development → mature form as actuality/end; then add "directedness, not conscious design".

Coverage-cell mapping: Four causes, organismic convergence and teleology — specifically internal directedness distinguished from design, Platonic imitation and mechanism.

PYQ linkage: Directly supports **2022 Q2(b)** on the consonance of the four causes and **2019 Q2(b)** on the reasons for developmental changes in substance.

MCQ 36. Applying the two substance questions

A horse is the ultimate subject of predicates such as "brown" and "swift", yet an enquirer asks why these bones and tissues constitute a horse rather than a heap. Which reading best applies Aristotle without conflating his texts?

- A. The *Categories* and *Metaphysics Z* give rival lists of primary substances, so one of the two accounts must be discarded.
- B. The *Categories* identifies the individual horse by subjecthood, while Z seeks the form or essence that explains the substancehood of that individual.
- C. The individual is primary in both works because form and essence are merely accidental predicates said of an independently complete matter.
- D. Form is primary in both works because the concrete horse is only a deficient copy of a separately existing equine universal.

Answer: B.

Option explanations: - **A:** Incorrect: the texts ask different questions at different explanatory depths; treating them as competing inventories creates a contradiction Aristotle need not hold. - **B:** Correct: *Categories* 2a11 identifies "this horse" as the ultimate subject, while *Metaphysics Z*.17 asks why this matter is this substance and answers through immanent form or essence. - **C:** Incorrect: bare matter is rejected as an adequate substance-candidate at Z.3, and substantial form is constitutive rather than an accident inhering in an already complete subject. - **D:** Incorrect: it imports Plato's separation into Aristotle; the equine form is the immanent explanatory principle of the concrete animal, not another-world exemplar.

Examiner trap 36: Memorising "primary substance = individual" and applying it unchanged to Z misses Aristotle's shift from identifying the bearer of predicates to explaining what makes that bearer the kind of substance it is.

Repair action: Use the formula: "*Categories*: which things are substances? — individuals. Z: what accounts for their substancehood? — form/essence as cause."

Coverage-cell mapping: Substance in the *Categories* and *Metaphysics Z* — specifically the applied distinction between subjecthood and causal-explanatory essence.

PYQ linkage: Strengthens the substance spine demanded by **2026 Q2(a)**, where Aristotle's account of the world's essence must move from concrete substance to hylomorphic and causal explanation.

MCQ 37. Pure actuality, immobility and final causation

Consider the following statements about Aristotle's Unmoved Mover.

1. Any unrealised potentiality would make it capable of being otherwise and therefore dependent on change for its fulfilment.
2. Its motion of the cosmos is final rather than efficient: it is desired and thought, not a body that transmits motion by contact.
3. Its immobility means that it can have no explanatory relation to motion and is retained only as an honorific name for the cosmos.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 2 and 3 only
- B. 1 and 3 only
- C. 1 and 2 only
- D. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: C.

Statement analysis: - **1 is correct:** potentiality is capacity for a state not yet actual; admitting it into the first principle would admit mutability, incompleteness and dependence, so pure actuality entails immobility. - **2 is correct:** *Metaphysics* XII (Λ).7 presents the mover as the object of desire and thought — "as the beloved moves the lover" — preserving its own changelessness. - **3 is incorrect:** immobility excludes being efficiently pushed or altered, not explanatory efficacy; final causation is precisely the relation by which it explains motion without undergoing motion.

Option explanations: - **A:** Incorrect: statement 2 is accurate, but statement 3 mistakes non-efficient causation for explanatory idleness. - **B:** Incorrect: statement 1 is accurate, but statement 3 removes the final-causal function that makes the doctrine part of Aristotle's causal system. - **C:** Correct: it joins the modal reason for immobility to the non-contact mode of final causation. - **D:** Incorrect: including statement 3 would reduce the Unmoved Mover to a label, contrary to its role as the terminus of the actuality–potentiality analysis.

Examiner trap 37: Candidates often infer either that an unmoved cause cannot cause or that the first mover must impart a first physical push. Both errors assume that all causation is efficient causation.

Repair action: Rehearse the dependency chain: potentiality → capacity to change → incompleteness; therefore pure actuality → immobility, while final attraction explains motion without contact.

Coverage-cell mapping: Unmoved Mover as pure actuality and final cause — specifically why absence of potentiality entails immobility and why motion is final-causal.

PYQ linkage: No directly owned PYQ isolates the Unmoved Mover, but this closes the argument used in **2020 Q1(a)** and **2023 Q2(b)** on actuality, potentiality and their priority.

MCQ 38. One problem, two rejected answers, one repair

Which option correctly matches Aristotle's objections to the Atomists and Plato with his positive account of sensible substance?

- A. Atomism and Platonism fail for the same reason, namely denial of particulars; Aristotle repairs both by making universals separate substances.
- B. Atomism wrongly multiplies immaterial universals; Plato wrongly reduces reality to collisions; Aristotle retains efficient causation alone.
- C. Atomism fails because atoms change their essences; Plato fails because Forms are material; Aristotle replaces both with prime matter alone.
- D. Atomism lacks internal form and final explanation; separated Forms lack immanent causal purchase; hylomorphic substances are explained through all four causes.

Answer: D.

Option explanations: - **A:** Incorrect: Atomists emphatically retain particulars, and Aristotle's solution is immanent rather than separated form. - **B:** Incorrect: it reverses the opponents' positions and then reduces Aristotle to the efficient-causal vocabulary whose incompleteness motivates his repair. - **C:** Incorrect: Aristotle's complaint is not that atoms change essence or that Forms are material; prime matter alone cannot explain a determinate substance. - **D:** Correct: Atomism preserves particulars and material-efficient processes but cannot explain substantial unity, form and end; Plato preserves intelligible form but separates it; hylomorphism and the four causes keep matter and form together.

Examiner trap 38: The two rejections are not interchangeable. Atomism puts too little form into its particulars; Platonism puts form in the wrong ontological place.

Repair action: Memorise the 2026 spine: one problem — what is substance?; two failures — form absent/form separated; one repair — form in the matter, explained by four causes.

Coverage-cell mapping: Fundamental metaphysics and the Atomist/Plato double rejection — specifically the paired defect and hylomorphic four-cause repair.

PYQ linkage: Directly maps to **2026 Q2(a)** on Aristotle's fundamental metaphysical problem and his rejection of both Atomists and Plato.

MCQ 39. Immanent form and the problem of universals

Why is it more accurate to say that Aristotle relocates, rather than simply eliminates, the problem of universals?

- A. He makes form immanent and causally explanatory, yet must still reconcile science's universal object with Z.13's denial that any universal is substance.
- B. He makes every species a separately existing substance, but locates that substance inside a physical place occupied by its instances.

C. He denies that definition concerns form, so knowledge must shift from universal essences to the accidental histories of individuals.

D. He treats universals as names only, although scientific definitions continue to use general terms as convenient summaries of individual histories.

Answer: A.

Option explanations: - **A:** Correct: immanence repairs separation and causal impotence, but Z.13 and the universality of scientific knowledge generate the disputed question whether substantial form is individual, species-level or differently universal. - **B:** Incorrect: "inside" is not a new physical address for a Platonic entity; immanence means that form constitutes the concrete compound as its essence and actuality. - **C:** Incorrect: definition targets essence or form, and scientific knowledge remains universal rather than becoming a chronicle of accidents. - **D:** Incorrect: Aristotle is not a nominalist; species and genera retain predicative and scientific reality even though they do not exist separately.

Examiner trap 39: Saying "Aristotle solved the universals problem" confuses a major advance with a final settlement. He removes a second realm, but the relation between the knowable universal essence and this individual substance remains contested.

Repair action: End comparison answers with a graded verdict: Aristotle defeats separation and improves causation, but the universal/particular status of immanent form remains a residual difficulty.

Coverage-cell mapping: Optional advanced dispute and Plato–Aristotle comparison — specifically the relocation of the universals problem into the status of immanent form.

PYQ linkage: Deepens **2024 Q1(a)** on their conceptions of form and supplies the qualification needed after Aristotle's positive answer in **2026 Q2(a)**.

MCQ 40. Blocking the regress without paying the causal debt

A Platonist denies that the Form of Large is large in the same way as a large mountain and therefore blocks the self-predication premise of the Third Man. What follows?

A. The theory is fully vindicated because every major Aristotelian objection to separated Forms, including causal impotence, depends on self-predication.

B. The specific regress is weakened, but participation still needs a non-metaphorical account of how separated Forms explain particulars and change.

C. The participation dilemma is solved because a non-self-predicating Form can be divided among its instances without itself having parts.

D. The causal problem disappears because denying self-predication converts each Form into the efficient cause of its sensible copies.

Answer: B.

Option explanations: - **A:** Incorrect: duplication, participation-as-metaphor, causal impotence and failure to explain generation do not require the self-predication premise. - **B:** Correct: the Third Man regress specifically depends on self-predication plus non-identity, but blocking that route leaves the theory's

central explanatory relation unanalysed. - **C:** Incorrect: the whole-or-part participation dilemma concerns whether a Form is present in participants and is independent of whether the Form predicates itself. - **D:** Incorrect: denying a premise of the regress assigns no efficient power to Forms and gives no mechanism by which separation produces motion or generation.

Examiner trap 40: Do not let the most famous objection stand for the whole critique. A successful reply to the Third Man can remove one regress while leaving participation and causal efficacy untouched.

Repair action: Sort the critique into two columns: "needs self-predication" — Third Man; "does not" — duplication, participation dilemma/metaphor, causal impotence and generation.

Coverage-cell mapping: Participation, imitation and Third Man — specifically why blocking self-predication does not discharge the independent participation and causal-efficacy burden.

PYQ linkage: Directly strengthens **2018 Q4(b)** on Aristotle's critique and **2021 Q1(a)** on participation by preventing a one-objection answer.